

World in Brief: Eastern Indonesia hit by earthquake; South Korea proposes Korean War talks



Photograph: Anadolu via Getty Images

A 7.7-magnitude earthquake struck eastern **Indonesia**, just off the coast of the island of Flores. At least 51 people were killed, but rescue teams have struggled to reach the region near the epicentre because of landslides. Just hours later, a 6.9-magnitude quake jolted northern Sumatra in the west of the country. There were no initial reports of casualties there.

[Lee Jae Myung](#), the president of **South Korea**, proposed talks with **North Korea** with a view to formally ending the Korean War. An armistice ended the hostilities in 1953, but the two countries remain technically at war. Mr Lee has made previous attempts at dialogue. But his tetchy northern neighbour, Kim Jong Un, has shown no interest in talking.

Moroccan police arrested at least 111 people who tried to enter Spain's North African exclave of **Ceuta**. Security has been tightened on both sides of the border after social media posts called again for people to cross over. At least 96 people died two weeks ago when some 72,000 migrants [surged](#) into Ceuta. Most returned to Morocco, but about 5,000 remain.

Narendra Modi has promised free online exam preparation and training for 10m young people in AI skills, just weeks after [protesters](#) vented their anger at problems in the education system. In a speech to mark the 79th anniversary of India's independence from Britain, the prime minister also renewed his pledge to make India a developed country within two decades.

The Taliban celebrated [five years in power](#) in **Afghanistan** with a parade in the capital, Kabul. In an address Sirajuddin Haqqani, the interior minister, mentioned the "divine assistance" that enabled the Taliban's return but also acknowledged, unusually, that "issues and problems...may still exist". UNESCO said this week that the Taliban have barred [2.4m girls](#) from secondary education since returning to power.

At least 11 people were killed by **Israeli** airstrikes on two villages in southern **Lebanon**. Israel said they were a response to attacks on its soldiers. The raids are indicative of the shakiness of a truce the two countries signed in June. This committed the Lebanese government to disarming Hizbullah, a Shia militia, and then Israel to withdrawing from Lebanese territory.

American **crime statistics** show the largest year-to-year decline in violent crime since FBI records began in 1936. Murder and non-negligent manslaughter decreased by 18.1% in 2025 while robberies fell by 18.5%. Violent crime overall fell by 9.3% and property crime by 12.4%. Donald Trump tried to take some credit, but [Democrats](#) pointed out that crime started declining before he returned to office.

Word of the week: pyrocumulonimbus, towering, smoke-tinged storm clouds that form above wildfires, supercharging them. [Read about how](#) researchers are collecting samples from these little-understood weather events.

Fourth term for Lula?



Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Campaigning for Brazil's election begins on Sunday, with the first presidential television debate taking place the same day. On October 4th the world's fourth-largest democracy will vote for a president, all state governors, the lower house and two-thirds of the Senate. [Our poll tracker](#) puts the 80-year old incumbent president, Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva, in the lead. If Lula emerges victorious he would become one of just a handful of presidents—including Franklin Roosevelt—to have won four free and fair elections.

His main challenger is Flávio Bolsonaro, son of Jair, a former president who is under house arrest for attempting to cling to power illegally in 2022. Many voters are dissatisfied with the leading candidates. A dark horse could emerge on the right to challenge Mr Bolsonaro. Keep an eye out on Renan Santos, a social-media-savvy millennial outsider. If no candidate wins a majority in the first round, a run-off will be held on October 25th.

Unwelcome to South Africa



Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

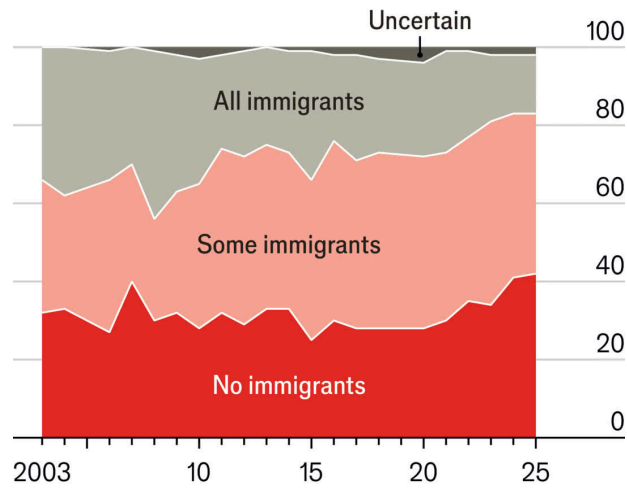
Leaders from southern Africa will converge on Durban, South Africa, this weekend for their annual summit. The official agenda for the Southern African Development Community, a 16-member group, is typically sprawling. Delegates will bloviate about regional integration, sustainable economic growth, poverty alleviation, and peace and security. Many of the leaders in attendance come from “liberation” parties with fraternal bonds. Little will be said about countries whose economies are stagnating (South Africa and Botswana) or whose governments are increasingly authoritarian (Zimbabwe and Tanzania, among others).

But the gathering may be a little less cosy than usual, given recent [anti-migrant protests](#) in South Africa. Vigilante groups reflect and exacerbate xenophobia among the public. In 2025 a poll found that 42% of South Africans wanted “no immigrants”, the highest percentage since surveys began in 2003. Thousands of migrants have been deported or chosen to leave. So much for regional integration.

Keep out

"I generally welcome to South Africa..."

% responding



No data for 2005 and 2019

Source: Human Sciences Research Council

Ozempic for the brain?



Photograph: Getty Images

Drugs that use glucagon-like peptide-1 (GLP-1) first treated diabetes before they began helping people shed weight. Now drugmakers are betting that two other peptides, the orexins, might follow a similar path. Last week an orexin agonist, a drug that mimics the molecules' action, was approved in America to treat narcolepsy. Drugmakers hope that orexins might one day help people with a host of other brain-related ailments, too.

[Orexins are neurotransmitters](#), chemicals that carry messages between neurons. They stimulate wakefulness-promoting systems that rely on other neurotransmitters, such as norepinephrine, serotonin and dopamine. Orexins keep these chemicals working together, like a conductor of an orchestra. Drugmakers are learning how to control the baton. Orexin antagonists—drugs that block the molecules' actions—have been used to treat insomnia since 2014. Now researchers are studying the effect of restoring the molecules' actions on more prevalent conditions, such as depression, ADHD and addiction. Robust testing is still needed. But the broad usefulness of GLP-1-based medicine has shown what targeting an entire regulatory system at once can achieve.

Weekend profile: Rob Sand, Democrats' best hope in Iowa



Photograph: Reuters

Last month, at a Methodist church in the middle of Iowa, Rob Sand handed a microphone to his internet troll. “Gary, good to see you,” the Democratic candidate for governor said. He probably meant it. By showing up to the town hall, Gary Leffler, a Republican activist known across the state for driving a Trump-themed tractor, gave Mr Sand the chance to put his money where his mouth is. “Talk is cheap, right?” said Mr Sand. He answered Mr Leffler’s questions thoughtfully.

Mr Sand’s town halls (he is about halfway through a tour of Iowa’s 99 counties) routinely feature Republicans, both supportive and sceptical—as well as a group sing-a-long of “America the Beautiful”. He talks up bipartisanship but actually seems to favour nonpartisanship, accusing the Democratic and Republican Parties, the “two private clubs” running American politics, of exploiting divisions to “pick our pockets”. The earnest schtick seems to be working for Mr Sand; a recent Emerson College poll showed him leading his Republican opponent by five points with three months to go before the November election. In Iowa, which has not elected a Democratic governor in 20 years, that is a big deal. Some Democrats are hopeful that Mr Sand’s strong campaign will buoy other Democratic candidates in the state, too.

Polished and sharp, the 44-year-old Mr Sand balances his Ivy League degree and a short career as a model with serious Iowa credibility. Growing up, he made pocket money catching chickens, which is even worse than it sounds: rounding up terrified capons in dark barns and loading them onto lorries. (Defecating, he remembered, was their “last line of defence”.) He turned down Harvard Law to attend the University of Iowa, then prosecuted corruption cases, including one against a sprawling lottery-rigging ring. He claims that, in his current role as the state’s auditor, he already serves as a check on power.

Accountability, oversight and civilised debate are focal points of Mr Sand’s campaign. Republicans, who have controlled the governorship and legislature for a decade, have left Iowa in a bad way: young, educated people are leaving, the economy is slowing and public schools are consolidating. But Mr Sand, keenly aware that Republicans outnumber Democrats in the state, avoids villainising others. He argues that bad outcomes are the result of process failures. Anything or anyone can spoil after a while. The solution? It’s “called crop rotation”, he says. “And it works for politicians too.”

The winners of this week's quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Gordon Gray, Virginia, America

Martyn Beardsell, Salzburg, Austria

Sharon Neal, London, Britain

They all gave the correct answers of: the Labour Party, the Albert memorial, Chris Columbus, Martin Luther King Jr and Independence, Missouri. The theme is us federal holidays; Labour Day, Memorial Day, Columbus Day, Martin Luther King Jr Day and Independence Day.

The questions were:

Monday: Which British political party, founded in 1900, produced prime ministers such as Ramsay MacDonald and Harold Wilson?

Tuesday: Which London landmark, designed by Sir George Gilbert Scott, features sculptures representing four continents, and four arts and sciences, as well as of the central figure it is named after?

Wednesday: Who directed the first two Harry Potter films?

Thursday: Which civil rights leader was baptised with the name of Michael, only to have his name changed by his father at the age of 5?

Friday: Which city is the site of the Truman Presidential Library?

*Look back, and smile on perils
past!*

Sir Walter Scott